

The Ecological Nature of Prejudice and Discrimination

History shows how prejudice and discrimination played a role in disrupting social harmony and facilitated the building of borders to create a sense of security and protection against “other” people. Unfortunately, this is still the case. Prejudice and discrimination still plague humanity and prevent the closing of the gap between countries, groups, and people even decades of interventions had been done. Is the eradication of prejudice and discrimination impossible? Perhaps, untrue. In this paper, I will suggest ways how to balance prejudice and discrimination in everyday life, and how crucial social institutions in their elimination from society. But first let us define what prejudice and discrimination are and where do they come from.

Prejudice and Discrimination

Prejudice is a negative attitude and prejudgement against a group and its members (Plous, 2003). They are mental shortcuts that people developed after years of socialization. Prejudice affects how individuals think about the world and life in general as well as how they feel about themselves and the people around them. It also forms the basis of stereotypes people hold towards groups (Plous, 2003). For instance, the rise in patriarchy and machismo culture have relegated women as “soft”, “weak”, and “trivial”. People have long held the belief that women are only good at home. The outside world is a game for physically strong men. The same thing is true for people of diverse sexual orientation, gender identity and expression, and sex characteristics (SOGIESC). People who identify as lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender (LGBT) have long been vilified to be people of danger, shame, and disgust. The saliency and prevalence of these negative attitudes have serious implications on the psychological well-being and survival of the members of these groups. Because where prejudice lurks, discrimination is far behind.

Discrimination, on the other hand, refers to unjust behaviors which are influenced by prejudice and stereotypes against a group and its members (Plous, 2003). It comes in various – verbal, physical, psychological, mental, and institutional. In other words, discrimination ranges from aggressive behaviors up to severe acts of violence that could result in the demise of the target group or people. To illustrate, prejudice and stereotypes against women as being weak and soft have prevented women from excelling in different fields like business, education, and science. For a time, women were discriminated against in schools by implementing policies like all-boys schools. Additionally, women are not promoted to higher positions in their industries because of their expected responsibilities as homemakers and child rearing. These instances are examples of institutional discrimination – policies, laws, and systems uphold prejudicial assumptions about groups. Similarly, the LGBT community are favorite subjects of prejudice and discrimination. The influential role of religious beliefs has resulted in the stigmatization of the LGBT people. Many have been harassed, persecuted, and maltreated because of their identities, that some hide in the closet to protect themselves, or at worst hate themselves for being one (*i.e., internalized homophobia*). Despite these unfortunate circumstances, no one can be solely blamed for the existence of prejudice and discrimination. The real problem lies in the system.

Prejudice and Discrimination are Systemic

No one is exempted from being victims or perpetrators of prejudice and discrimination. This is a fact. For once in their lives, people have prejudice and stereotypes that resulted in the

discrimination of other people. Hence, no matter how hard one tries not to discriminate, it is inevitable. This is because prejudice and discrimination are systemic issues. They are the root causes of economic and social inequalities.

Society operates according to the perspectives and tenets espoused by major social institutions namely government, education, media, religion, and the family. These social institutions work together to create the space where people socialize and the reality where people exist. To illustrate, the laws that govern the land are implemented by the government. Which behavior or identity is criminalized are dictated by the laws and policies enacted by the government. For a time, homosexual people are criminalized in the US. Members of the LGBTQIA community were arrested, incarcerated, and tortured because of their SOGIESC (Geoghegan, 2019). This happened because of anti-gay laws enacted by the government. Since they are an influential institution, the belief that LGBTQIA people deviant or abnormal have penetrated the minds of the public that some had opted to help in the eradication of these identities. The same thing is true for people of Islam. The Zionist movement of Jews have led to extreme violence and inhumane treatment of the Palestinians for a long period of time (Rouhana & Bar-Tal, 1998). The religious belief of Israelis that they are the rightful owners of the land of Palestine have led them to discriminate and perpetuate prejudicial attitudes towards Palestinians.

On the other hand, education as a social institution is also influential in proliferating prejudice and discrimination. One of the inklings of why Philippine education is rotten is its role in propagating gender stereotypes. For a long time, the Philippine basic education curriculum has taught its students of how women are homemakers, men are breadwinners, and the LGBTQIA are non-existent. This issue of gender stereotyping had been successful in preventing outgoing Vice President Leni Robredo from her presidential bid as voters were reluctant to vote for a candidate who has exemplary track record and excellent platforms because of her being female (Wong, 2022). Likewise, media has also its fair share of influence in the cultivation, maintenance, and propagation of prejudice and discrimination. According to Plous (2003), advertisements have a strong influence in social perception and behavior. The parasocial nature of media influences its viewers to act obediently. For instance, a Hong Kong free-to-air television drama has depicted a Filipino woman as a domestic helper who is trying to make a living in one of the developed countries in Asia (Lam, 2022). Although it is true that there are Filipino people who work as domestic helpers, it is prejudicial and discriminatory to choose a Filipino woman to play such role. This would only propagate and denigrate the Filipino nationality as “inferior” and “unintellectual” people who live to serve the elite class of other countries.

Unfortunately, the people who should protect and combat against prejudice and discrimination are also the people who propagate them with their families. The power of media, education, politics, and religion have influenced the culture and dynamics of the most basic unit of society. The roles and expectations of parents from children and vice versa resembles the roles and expectations of these institutions to the wider society.

Prejudice and Discrimination can be Eliminated Individually and Collectively

After knowing what is prejudice and discrimination as well as the system where we operate is the culprit of their existence, how do we move forward? How do we change the direction of our narrative? Ideally speaking, overhauling the system is the best way to go. However, this long-term solution would be difficult to achieve as the elite and “powerful” would stall the fruition of this endeavor. Hence, the complexity of this solution involves a united stance and force emanating from the people, which lives and directly experiences the effects of

prejudice and discrimination. Consequently, establishing a united front is a major roadblock. Meanwhile, a viable option to reduce prejudice and discrimination is to introduce progressive laws and policies (Plous, 2003). The constitution grants and recognizes that all people are born equal. Therefore, reforms through legislation should be advocated to senators and representatives. In this way, progress would be achieved, and there would be less resistance from the elite and “powerful”. For instance, the protection of the rights of women and elimination of discrimination under the Magna Carta for Women was a glimmer of hope that is possible to reduce the impact of institutional discrimination (Republic Act 9710: Magna Carta of Women, 2009). Light was also shown to people who have been victims of the untreatable (as of this writing) human immunodeficiency virus (HIV). The passage of comprehensive policy that criminalizes discrimination of people living with HIV did not only help in reducing institutional discrimination, but also in their destigmatization (Republic Act No. 11166: Philippine HIV and AIDS Policy Act, 2018). These landmark laws prove that collective struggle is one of the means to eradicate prejudice and discrimination. Thus, successful enactments of these laws would result in changing social norms that govern society.

On a more personal note, there are a wide array of strategies to effectively combat prejudice and discrimination. Developing a high sense of self-awareness is the essence of all these strategies. Empathy building and role playing has been found to reduce prejudice, stereotyping, and discrimination (Plous, 2003). People change behavior and beliefs about groups and individuals when they take on the perspective of the target group or individual being stereotyped and discriminated against. Allowing people to see the world in the eyes of others would bring change through understanding and social connectedness. Additionally, empathy is one of the most flexible strategies because of its applicability in various contexts (Plous, 2003). For instance, empathy towards women and LGBTQIA are similar in execution and function.

Aside from empathy building and role playing, contact hypotheses by Gordon Allport have been suggested to fight against prejudice (Plous, 2003). The contact hypothesis argues that contact between groups can help to eliminate prejudice about the target group by reducing the prejudicial groups’ anxiety. This anxiety is brought by the negative attitudes they hold against the target group (Hopper, 2020). Moreover, by having contact between groups, empathy is cultivated by allowing both groups to see the world in the eyes of each other. For instance, it was suggested by Cohen and Insko (2008) that intergroup contact can help in reducing the gravity of Israeli-Palestinian conflict. By correcting their prejudices toward the outgroup, they can shift focus to their similarities and more important things.

Ultimately, challenging your own biases, doing constant reflection, and calling out instead of canceling people out are effective ways of battling prejudice and discrimination. It is a fact that people would be prone to commit prejudice and discrimination unknowingly. This is a result of a long history of subjugation with patriarchy and various nations of power that spoiled a group’s identity, beliefs, and culture. But it does not justify the enactment of prejudice and discrimination. Meanwhile, if someone committed discriminatory actions toward a group or individual, it is our duty to call out these people. Calling them out generates discourse. Discourse generates understanding. Understanding generates empathy. Empathy extinguishes prejudice.

Conclusion

Prejudice and discrimination have led us to where we are today. Its systemic nature is the reason why people continue to study and find ways to eradicate them. Sadly, it continues to blanket the world today as more and more countries disintegrate and divide. But not all hope is

lost. The existence of mechanisms like the legal system and effective strategies are indications that humanity is towards the right direction. Hence, with various collective and individual efforts, it is not impossible that future generations would hear a different narrative of how the world is a better place because diversity, inclusivity, and equality reign.

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